5.11.7 Differences between classical and modern taxonomy

Classical Taxonomy	Modern Taxonomy
It is called old systematics or Alpha (ά) taxonomy or Taxonomy	It is called Neosystematics or Biosystematics or Omega (Ω) taxonomy
It is pre Darwinean	It is post Darwinean
Species is considered as basic unit and is static	species is considered as dynamic entity and ever changing
Classification is mainly based on morphological characters	Classification is based on morphological, reproductive characters and phylogenetic (evolutionary) relationship of the organism
This system is based on the observation of a few samples/ individuals	This system is based on the observation of large number of samples/individuals

5.12 Cladistics

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Analysis of the taxonomic data, and the types of characters that are used in classification have changed from time to time. Plants have been classified based on the morphology before the advancement of microscopes, which help in the inclusions of **sub microscopic** and **microscopic** features. A closer study is necessary while classifying closely related plants. Discovery of new finer molecular analytical techniques coupled with advanced software and computers has ushered in a new era of modern or phylogenetic classification.

The method of classifying organisms into monophyletic group of a common ancestor based on shared apomorphic characters is called **cladistics** (from Greek, *klados*-branch).

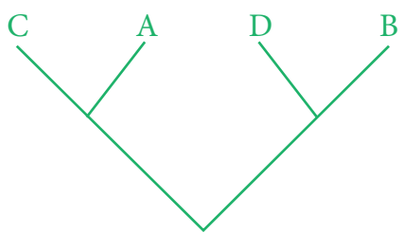
The outcome of a cladistic analysis is a **cladogram**, a tree-shaped diagram that represent the best hypothesis of phylogenetic relationships. Earlier generated cladograms were largely on the basis of morphological characters, but now genetic sequencing data and computational softwares are commonly used in phylogenetic analysis.

Cladistic analysis

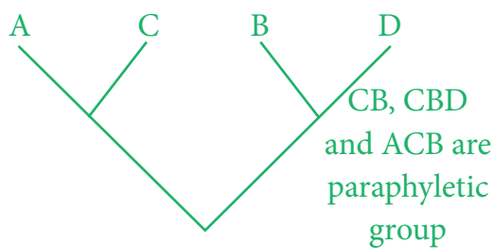
Cladistics is one of the primary methods of constructing phylogenies, or evolutionary histories. Cladistics uses shared, derived characters to group organisms into clades. These clades have atleast one shared, derived character found in their most recent common ancestor that is not found in other groups hence they are considered more closely related to each other. These shared characters can be morphological such as, leaf, flower, fruit, seed and so on; behavioural, like opening of flowers nocturnal/diurnal; molecular like, DNA or protein sequence and more.

Cladistics accept only **monophyletic groups**. **Paraphyletic** and **polyphyletic** taxa are occasionally considered when such taxa conveniently treated as one group for practical purposes. Example: dicots, sterculiaceae. Polyphyletic groups are rejected by cladistics.

i. **Monophyletic group;** Taxa comprising all the descendants of a common ancestor.



ii. Paraphyletic group; Taxon that includes an ancestor but not all of the descendants of that ancestor.



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